

EPISODE 4 (SESSION 1)

His Bow in the Clouds

PRIMARY TEXT: GENESIS 6–9

The so-called “Lullaby Effect” seems to have taken effect for many of us when we look back at stories like the flood of Genesis. Yet when we study it in proximity to stories such as Cain’s, that tell us God’s position on humanity hasn’t changed, things don’t add up. *God is good, believes in us, and now He’s decided to give up on it? Will He give up on me?*

When we look at the context and purpose of this story, we discover even more about our God and how he is so different from the gods the world followed. This new mindset of looking at context and cultural norms changes some of the questions we ask or the fears that we have. Elle gives us specific examples from one the most famous flood narratives (outside of the narrative in Genesis) and we can begin to see part of the importance of this story being told the way that it was in these ancient Near East, Sumerian worlds.

“In those days, the world teemed. The people multiplied. The world bellowed like a wild bull. And the great god was aroused by the clamor. ... The uproar of mankind is intolerable and sleep is no longer possible by reason of the babel. So the gods agreed to exterminate mankind.”

-Tablet XI, *Epic of Gilgamesh*

The Lord saw how great the wickedness of the human race had become on the earth, and that every inclination of the thoughts of the human heart was only evil all the time. The Lord regretted ..., and his heart was deeply troubled. So the Lord said, “I will wipe from the face of the earth the human race I have created... .” But Noah found favor in the eyes of the Lord.

Genesis 6:5–8, NIV

Here, multiple angry gods are *annoyed* with humanity—they can’t get any sleep! In contrast, the (one) God of Genesis sees evil and *harm being done on or to creation*. Thinking back to the previous episode, humanity is letting itself be mastered by the beast and will not choose to do the next right thing. God isn’t against humanity or annoyed by it. God is against the violence and chaos being committed by humanity, and he wants to take care of it quickly. He plans to destroy it all, but—He interrupts His own plans when he sees Noah.

“Even the gods were terrified at the flood. They fled to the highest heaven. They crouched against the walls, cowering like curs.”

-Tablet XI, *Epic of Gilgamesh*

The Lord then said to Noah, “Go into the ark, you and your whole family, because I have found you righteous in this generation. [more directions for saving more of creation] And Noah did all that the Lord commanded him.

Genesis 7:1, 5 NIV

In one story, the gods have lost control and, terrified, cower from the chaos they created. In contrast, the audience of the flood story in Genesis sees God in control of the floodwaters with a plan to save creation, including humanity. God partners with Noah and his family, still believing in their goodness.

This God—our God—isn't like the other gods. This Genesis flood narrative steps outside its cultural norms to draw our attention to these vital differences. God is against evil. There is one true God. God knows when to stop destroying.

Even though we may let the beast master us sometimes. Even though we worry. Even though we doubt—God doesn't want us to enter into a relationship with Him leveraged by fear, worry, or power. Humanity needed to learn this, and God knew that at some point humanity would need to be reminded. So he paints a reminder of his promise in the clouds. So he pointed a bow, aimed at the heavens, to always remind us all.

Imagine with me. You step outside the moment after a storm has begun to clear and look up to the sky. The remaining moisture in the air sticks to you as you look up into the expanse above. Shades of red, orange, yellow, green, blue, and violet painted over the earth, beyond the clouds. Then a calming wind, *ruach*, whispers *I remember my promise; you don't need to prove anything to me.*

PRAYER

*We bless you, God,
for loving us, for pursuing us,
and for painting in the clouds
a reminder of your promise to us.
We bless you, God, for being different.
For being the One who partners with us
in restoring your creation. Your Kingdom.
We bless you, God, for knowing when to stop.*

*May we hold this love, this covenant,
this partnership, close to us—
always.*

THE FOUR PILLARS

EPISODE 4

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the Story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

What piece of Genesis 6–9 could you meditate over and memorize this week? What could you carry with you? (Check out our YouVersion Reading Plans to help guide you.)



COMMUNITY

What intentional relationships help you practice unity and goodness? Who surrounds you and helps you look to the promise God makes in this story over the lies the world tells you?



DISCIPLESHIP

Who would be impacted by the reminder of God's promise to stop destroying? Who needs to hear that this God is different than the God of our culture or childhood? How might you encounter these people more?



WRESTLING

What questions do you have after this lesson? Remember, questions are good! Questions were/are the point. What are you still wrestling with, and why? How can you wrestle with fear and insecurity to better trust the story?



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 1



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE SPIRITUAL FORMATION

*True success is developing intimacy with God, and **part of that intimacy is believing that God has not given up on or left you.** God knows your worth and wants you to remember it. What spaces do you have, or could you create, for God to enter into to help you remember this and challenge you to do the next right thing? Is this sacred devotional time, small groups, prayer, other spiritual disciplines?*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

*We believe young adults are shaping the future of this world. And so often it is these young adults who give up on faith because they are told or somehow believe they are too far gone to be loved by God. **How can you remind young people of the goodness God has spoken over them?** How could you remind them that God's position on them has not changed, and help them realize how to do the next right thing?*

SACRED STATION THEOLOGY OF WORK

*Do you see those at your "work" in the goodness God sees them in? Do we see others through their mistakes, or do we see them in the image God created them? How we bring life to others is something God says is central to our presence in the world—and believing in their ability to do better or do the next right thing is also characterized so heavily in the person of Jesus. The way we manage employees and interact with customers or coworkers says a lot about the God we believe in and what that God believes about the people we encounter. **The work we do every day is sacred. It matters—and so does the belief in the potential of ourselves and others in this space.***